



Case Study: Pocket FM

Category: Audio entertainment + monetized fiction **Audience:** Bharat users, esp. Tier 2/3 + blue-collar & gig economy **USP:** Serialized audio stories (romance, thriller, drama) **Monetization:** Micro-transactions per episode or bundles

🚩 Flawed Feature: Episode-Based Microtransactions (“Pay to Continue”)

💣 The Problem:

After 4–5 free episodes, users must **pay ₹9–₹19 per episode** to continue listening. This creates friction because:

- The **stories are addictive**, and users feel trapped — not rewarded.
- Many users **abandon midway** due to sudden paywall fatigue.
- Instead of joy or loyalty, Pocket FM creates a **hostage-style model**.

Why It Hurts Product Quality:

Problem	Impact
✗ Poor perceived value	₹200+ per story feels unreasonable in low-income segments
✗ Abrupt monetization	No gradual build-up of trust, just a hard paywall
✗ Declining story completion rate	Users churn at paywall cliff
✗ Negative reviews	App Store ratings mention pricing trickery

Feature Redesign: “Pocket Pass” – Story Club Model with Gamified Access

The Idea:

Introduce a **story subscription model** where users can:

- Pay a flat fee (e.g., ₹29/month) for **access to 3–5 stories of their choice**, OR
- **Earn access** by listening daily, sharing with friends, or rating stories.

Think of it like a **Netflix x Daily Rewards** model for fiction lovers.

Feature Components:

1 Pocket Pass Subscription

Flat-rate monthly pass to access unlimited or 3–5 curated stories.

2 Story Club Missions

Daily micro-tasks to unlock story credits:

- Listen 10 mins → earn 1 credit
- Share a story → earn 2 credits
- Daily streak → unlock episode

3 Spin the Wheel (Retention Layer)

Weekly spin to win free episodes or credits

Why It Works:

Value Prop	Outcome
💰 Affordable pricing model	Users feel in control, not manipulated
🎮 Gamified access	Boosts daily engagement + unlock dopamine loop
🌱 Gradual monetization	Smooth trust build → higher conversion
📁 Surprise & delight	Keeps free users engaged (improves funnel top & middle)



Suggested Metrics to Track:

Metric	Why
Story Completion Rate	Higher = stronger narrative hook + monetization success
Daily Active Users	Should improve via mission loop
Conversion to Pocket Pass	Signals if pricing hits the sweet spot
Referral Rate	If shared stories = strong hook

Strategic Impact:



Reduces churn and paywall rage



Converts passive listeners to active community members



Builds a long-term retention loop around stories and social engagement



Differentiates Pocket FM from Kuku FM (utility-driven) & Audible (premium static pricing)

Would you like:

-  A full written case study (PDF or Notion-ready)
-  Figma wireframes of “Pocket Pass” and “Story Club”
-  Monetization funnel redesign slides
-  Custom tailoring based on a company you're applying to (e.g., CRED, Flipkart, etc.)